

Sovereignty, Plainly: Why the Next Personal Computer Keeps the Record

What sovereignty has always meant, where digital life stands against it, and how a personal machine can be built to honor it.

1 • What sovereignty has always meant

Sovereignty is not a technology word. It is the oldest working question in governance, and it has always had two halves: **who decides, and who holds the record?**

Every durable answer to that question has been built out of a small number of parts, and they have barely changed in eight hundred years.

Consent. Authority that is not granted is merely exercised. The distinction between a government and an occupation, between a contract and a demand, is whether the person bound by it agreed to be bound. Consent that cannot be withheld is not consent; it is a formality performed on the way to compliance.

Written law above a ruler's discretion. The move from "what the lord decides today" to "what the charter says" is the single most consequential upgrade in the history of governance. It is not that written law is wiser. It is that written law is *the same tomorrow as it was yesterday*, and that a person can read it in advance and plan a life around it. Discretion may be benevolent. It is still discretion.

The record as a right, not a favor. This is the part people forget, and it is the part this paper is about. Due process and property have always depended on documents a person can physically hold. Medieval English parties to an agreement wrote it twice on one sheet of parchment, then cut the sheet apart along an irregular line — a practice called the chirograph — so each side walked away with a half, and the halves had to match. Debts were recorded on a wooden tally stick split lengthwise, so that the grain itself authenticated the pair. Deeds, charters, notarial books, parish registers, bills of lading: the whole apparatus of ordinary rights runs on evidence held by the person whose rights they are.

The reason is not sentimentality about paper. It is that a record held by one party to a dispute is a record that party can lose, revise, or decline to produce.

A record you must ask someone else for is not a record you hold. It is a courtesy, and courtesies end.

Powers granted, enumerated, and checked — never assumed. A sovereign arrangement lists what an authority may do, and treats everything unlisted as forbidden rather than available. It then splits the doing: one body proposes, another consents, a third records. The splitting is not inefficiency. It is the mechanism.

The right to exit. Every one of the above fails eventually if the person cannot leave. Emigration, the freedom to withdraw from an association, the ability to take one's property and one's papers and go — exit is what keeps the other rights honest, because an authority that cannot be left has no reason to keep its promises.

Those five are the whole grammar: consent, written rule, held record, enumerated and checked power, and the door. Any system that has all five has something worth calling sovereignty. Any system missing one is running on the goodwill of whoever is missing it.

2 • A short constitutional echo

The American founding is a useful worked example — not because it is the only one, and not because software is a constitution, but because the founders were solving precisely the design problem described above and left unusually legible notes.

They enumerated powers, and wrote down that anything not enumerated was not granted. They split a single act of government across separate hands so that no one hand could complete it alone. They required a public record — journals of proceedings, published laws, courts of record — on the theory that a citizen should be able to read what was done in their name rather than petition for a summary of it. They built an amendment process, so that change to the rules was itself governed by rules, rather than by whoever happened to hold power at the moment change became convenient. And in the Declaration they set out the logic of last resort: when a government becomes destructive of its ends, the governed may withdraw and constitute another.

The echoes to a machine built on the same grammar are close enough to be useful:

- **Enumerated powers** ↔ a machine that has only the authorities its owner has explicitly granted, and refuses anything not on the list.
- **Checks and balances** ↔ propose, approve, execute — three separated steps, with no way to skip the middle one.
- **The public record** ↔ a ledger the person holds outright, rather than a report they request from the party they might one day need to dispute.
- **The amendment process** ↔ changes to the machine's own rules that are themselves made under the rules, and recorded like every other decision.
- **The Declaration's logic** ↔ the fork: the right to take the whole work and go, treated not as a threat to the project but as the project's own designated remedy.

The claim here is small and specific. It is not that a program is a polity, or that a license is a bill of rights. It is that **the design questions are the same questions** — who may act, on whose authority, with what record, and what happens when the arrangement fails — and that they have known answers which we are, at the moment, mostly not using.

3 · The landscape today, honestly

Set the five parts against ordinary digital life and read the results plainly. These are dynamics, not villains; most of them arose from reasonable engineering and reasonable economics, and no one had to intend the outcome for it to arrive.

Accounts that can be closed are not property. A great deal of what people now call "theirs" — correspondence, photographs, books, business records, the operating history of a company — exists as a permission on someone else's system. The permission is usually honored. It is still a permission, revocable by policy change, payment failure, automated misclassification, corporate acquisition, or lawful order to a third party the owner never met.

Terms that change unilaterally are not consent. Agreements that one side may amend at will, with notice deemed accepted by continued use, are not contracts in the sense the word carried for most of its history. They are announcements. Again: usually benign, structurally one-sided.

A record held by the platform is a privilege, not a right. Export exists on most services, and it is a genuine good. But an export is a copy produced on request, in a format the producer chose, at a time the producer permits, with no independent way to prove that what came out matches what was there. That is a very different object from a document you have held, continuously, since the day it was made.

The question	When the platform holds it	When you hold it
Where does the record live?	On infrastructure you don't control	On hardware you control
What if the relationship ends?	Access ends with the relationship	The record is unaffected
Who can change it?	Whoever operates the system	Any change breaks a visible chain
Who can verify it?	You can view what you're shown	Anyone you hand it to can re-check it

Frontier AI concentrates capability. The most capable systems require capital, hardware, energy, and specialized talent at a scale available to a small number of organizations, situated in a small number of jurisdictions. That concentration is not a conspiracy; it is a consequence of the cost curve. But it produces a small number of points at which capability can be priced, throttled, redirected, or compelled — and compulsion does not require malice from the operator, only sufficient pressure on it. When a person's thinking, drafting, deciding, and remembering all route through such a point, the person's sovereignty is exactly as durable as that point's independence.

And then there is the commons. Open-weight models are one of the genuinely good developments of this decade. Capable models with published weights, runnable on hardware an individual or a small firm can buy, are the reason a personal sovereign machine is possible at all. They are what a machine like the one described in the next section is designed to run. Our stance toward that commons is collaboration and gratitude, not rivalry: the architecture in this paper contributes nothing to model capability and depends entirely on it. Every improvement in open weights is an improvement to this design's ceiling.

The honest complication is that the *surroundings* of open weights can still concentrate even when the weights do not. Serving infrastructure, distribution channels, package registries, tooling defaults, and hosted convenience all tend toward a few providers, because that is what convenience does. Weights being open is necessary. It has never been sufficient.

No doom in any of this. It is simply the map: a landscape where capability is abundant and rising, and where the five old parts of sovereignty — consent, written rule, held record, enumerated power, exit — are less present in digital life than in a fourteenth-century land transfer.

4 · The idea of the sovereign node

Here is the thing itself, described as it works.

A sovereign node is one person's machine. Or a family's, or a small firm's. It sits on hardware they own, in a building they occupy. It is designed to run open-weight models locally — that is the intended operating mode, stated here as intent. It keeps a permanent, signed record of what it did and what it was told, and that record lives on that machine, in the owner's physical possession. It is governed by four principles that are not features to be toggled but conditions written into the license the software is offered under — a copy that runs without them is not a licensed copy.

The four are stated in plain terms in the repository's governance document. Here they are, each with the mechanism that makes it real rather than aspirational.

The person decides

The machine may propose. A human approves. Only then does anything execute.

The scene: the node has drafted a decision — a filing, a commitment, a change to a record of consequence — and it stops. It has not sent anything. It presents what it wants to do and waits for a person to say yes. Trivial things run free; anything material stops at the gate.

What keeps this from being a promise in a manual: when a consequential action reaches a machine with no human gate available, it is not quietly permitted. It is **refused**, and the refusal is written into the record as a refusal. The governance document states this directly, and it is enforced in the source: the parts of the node that actually execute code accept only the owner's authenticated approval. That ordering — approval is authorization logic, not documentation — is the difference between a design and a discipline.

Nothing is permitted until the owner permits it

The machine starts with no authority at all. Every capability it has is one its owner granted, in a written declaration the owner can read. Anything undeclared is refused.

The scene: a role the node can play — a bookkeeper, a records clerk, a research assistant — arrives with its capabilities listed in a plain configuration file. The owner reads the list. What is on the list is what it can do. There is no ambient permission, no capability

that comes along quietly with an update, no default that grows more generous over time. Adding power is always an explicit, visible act, and looks like one.

The record cannot be quietly rewritten

Every action of consequence appends an entry to a chain, and each entry is cryptographically linked to the one before it. The owner holds the chain.

The scene, and this is the one that matters most: a year later, someone questions what happened. The owner does not file a request. They re-run the verification on their own machine, and the chain either reconciles or it does not. If an entry was altered after the fact, the links no longer match, and the break is loud rather than subtle: tampering does not leave a quietly plausible history behind it. And the check does not depend on trusting whoever handed the record over — anyone holding a copy can re-run it.

The point is not that the record is impossible to attack. The point is that a successful attack cannot be a silent one.

It never quietly extends itself

The node grows only by validation against the owner's declared rules. New roles load through specification validation. New code enters through the owner's review. Growth is a decision, recorded like every other decision.

This is the condition people underestimate. A system that can quietly acquire capabilities has, in effect, an unwritten constitution — whatever it happened to acquire is what it is. Making extension an explicit, validated, recorded event is what keeps the other three principles from eroding by accretion.

And the condition on all of it

The license makes those four conditions of use rather than selling points. Anyone may read, run, modify, redistribute, and fork the work; forking is explicitly encouraged, and the license says in its own words that if the project ever fails its own principles, forking it is the intended remedy. What is not permitted is stripping the protections and continuing to operate under this grant: a fork that removes the human gate at runtime, or locks an operator's records into formats they cannot read and verify, or requires the distributor's servers and accounts to function, is outside the grant.

Forking is not this project's failure mode. It is this project's designated remedy — written into the license as a right, so that the answer to "what if they go wrong?" is a door rather than an appeal.

Rights travel with the copy. That is the entire point of doing it in a license rather than a promise.

5 • From one node to a constellation

One node, sitting alone, already answers most of the question. Its owner decides, its owner holds the record, and its owner can walk away with everything. That is the working foundation, and it is the honest description of what functions today.

The interesting part is what happens when there are many — and everything in this section describes design being built toward, not a running network.

Independent nodes can strengthen each other without any of them becoming a center. The design is mutual witnessing: when two nodes transact, each keeps a signed copy of the exchange, so the evidence of what happened exists in two houses instead of one. Extend that across many nodes and you would get a fabric with a useful property — no node is the authoritative one. Losing any single machine would not erase the history it participated in, because the counterparties hold their halves. It is the chirograph, at

scale: cut the parchment, both sides keep a piece, and the pieces have to match. It is also what would carry the record's guarantee to its strongest form — a history that cannot be quietly rewritten even by the person who holds it, because the matching halves live in other houses.

What that design buys, stated plainly, is **resilience by construction rather than by policy**. There would be no headquarters to capture, subpoena, acquire, or pressure, because there would be no headquarters. Not as a security claim about any particular attack, but as a structural fact about where the parts are.

The license already anticipates this and writes the peering right into the terms:

"Nodes running this work or derivatives may federate freely. No party may charge rent, demand registration, or impose gatekeeping as a condition of federation protocol compatibility. The right to peer is part of the work."

And now the maturity statement, said exactly as it should be said. **The single node and its record are what works today. The wider constellation — production-scale propagation across many independent nodes — is the design being built toward, not a running network.** There is no live mesh to point at, and we would rather say so plainly than describe a simulation as a deployment. The foundation is real and inspectable; the fabric on top of it is architecture and intent, and this paper labels it as such wherever it appears.

6 • The honest trade

Anyone considering this should understand precisely what they are giving up, because it is real and it is not small.

A personal node is slower. A machine you can afford, in a room you occupy, does not have the compute of a data center. Responses take longer. Long tasks take much longer.

It is less fluent. Open-weight models runnable on consumer hardware trail the frontier's best on the qualities people notice first — range, polish, the uncanny ease of the very largest systems. The gap has narrowed remarkably fast. But at any given moment, the frontier is ahead.

It may never match the frontier's peak. This is the part that should not be softened with a projection. Concentrated capital buys capability, and there is no argument here that a personal machine will one day be as capable as the largest systems in existence. It may not. The bet is not that the gap closes to zero. The bet is that a personal machine becomes *good enough for the work that matters most to a person*, which is a much lower bar. The bet, specifically, is that capable open models are at or near that bar for drafting, analysis, bookkeeping, records, research, and judgment support — a judgment any reader can test on their own hardware rather than take from us.

So what is bought with that trade?

A different good entirely. The node **records what its owner holds true, protects that record against loss, revision, and compulsion, and keeps final authority with the person.** Decisions, memory, and their transfer across generations remain human property. Not licensed. Not hosted. Not contingent on a relationship continuing, a company surviving, a price holding, or a jurisdiction staying friendly.

The repository's governance document makes the case beyond safety, in economic terms, and it is worth quoting because it is the actual argument:

"Authority that stays with people is what lets prosperity compound to people. A system whose decisions originate in human intent — and whose record of those decisions can be handed, intact, to the next generation — builds wealth that belongs to a family line, not to whoever operates the machine. The tool serves the living; the living answer for the tool. That ordering is the whole architecture."

Read that against the trade. A frontier system will draft your memo faster and better. It will not hand your grandchildren an intact, verifiable account of what your family decided, why, and on whose authority — because that record was never yours to hand. It was a view into a system, and views close.

The choice is not "fast machine or slow machine." It is: *is the thing I most need from a computer speed, or is it that what I put into it stays mine, stays true, and outlives the arrangement I bought it under?* For a great many tasks the honest answer is speed, and the frontier should be used, cheerfully, for those. For decisions, records, and inheritance, the answer changes.

7 • What you can check yourself

Nothing in this paper asks to be believed on our word, and none of it rests on anything you cannot check yourself.

The repository is public — github.com/mangumcfo/sovereign-agent-starter. The license is a plain text file at its root — the four conditions, the fork right, the anti-capture terms, and the peering clause are all readable in about ten minutes, by you, without asking anyone. The governance document states each condition, and points at the code enforcing the approval gate and the record. The record-keeping, the approval gate, the refusal path, and the verification command are ordinary source files you can open and read; the installation path is documented in the readme as a short clone-and-install sequence that stands up a working node locally. That it runs on hardware you control, without requiring accounts, remote approval, telemetry, or services owned by the distributor, is not a marketing line — it is a condition the license itself imposes on every copy, including ours, and you can read the clause. The repository ships its full test suite — clone it and run it.

Where this paper describes something that works, you can go look at it. Where it describes something we are building toward — the wider constellation, in particular — it says so in the same sentence, every time. There is no third category, and if you find one, that is a defect worth reporting.

This is an invitation, not a dare. The most useful thing a skeptical reader can do with an architecture like this one is treat its claims as a to-do list and check them off personally. That is what the license makes lawful and the repository makes practical.

8 • Closing

Sovereignty was never really about machines.

It is about whether a person's truths — what they decided, what they own, what they meant, what they promised and were promised in return — have a home the person controls. Every institution we built to protect those truths was, at bottom, a way of keeping a durable record in the hands of the person it belonged to: the split parchment, the deed in the drawer, the courthouse book, the enumerated power, the open door.

For most of a generation we have been quietly moving those truths into systems where the record is a view, the terms are an announcement, and the door is a feature that may be deprecated. Nobody decided this. It happened because it was convenient, and it was convenient because the alternative was hard to build.

That alternative is no longer out of reach. Capable models are open. Hardware is affordable. The record-keeping is arithmetic that has been well understood for decades. What was missing was the discipline to put the person back at the origin of the decision and the record back in the person's hands — and to write that discipline somewhere it could not be quietly removed later.

A constellation of personal nodes is one attempt at that. It is early, it is honest about which parts run and which parts are drawings, and it is offered under terms designed to make it survivable without us. If it fails its own principles, the license hands you the tools to take it and do better.

Capture requires a center. A constellation, built honestly, does not have one.